Ram Vilas Paswan) twenty-five. The Nitish Kumar-led Janata Dal (United) JD(U)–BJP alliance was swept to power by a record margin. As Lalu Prasad wistfully remarked, '*Woh doob gaye, hamein bhi dooba diya!'* (The Congress drowned, and took us down with them).

The double blow of failure in UP and Bihar affected Rahul. The political confidence generated by the 2009 election win was ebbing away. 'I think the self-doubts that were always lurking in the shadows began to take over. He felt and looked like a loser, like someone who felt he wasn't really cut out for this. It almost seemed as if he had lost the appetite to fight back,' says a senior Congressman. Rahul withdrew into his shell and became almost risk-averse. He had promised to travel extensively through UP and rejuvenate the cadres. He did no such thing. At a time when the Congress was looking for leadership, the leader went missing.

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Former Israeli prime minister Abba Eban once said, 'The Palestinians never miss an opportunity to miss an opportunity.' Much the same could be said of Rahul Gandhi in 2011 and 2012, two crucial years ahead of the 2014 elections. In 2011, an agitation led by social activist Anna Hazare, demanding the setting up of an anti-corruption ombudsman, called the Lok Pal, shook the nation. For two weeks in August, a seventy-four-year-old Gandhian from Maharashtra became a symbol of the growing public disgust with corruption. Hazare had vowed to go on a fast from 16 August if the Jan Lok Pal Bill was not passed. Sonia Gandhi had gone abroad for surgery for an undisclosed medical condition. Before leaving, she had set up a four-member committee to look after the daily affairs of the Congress. The committee had veteran leaders A.K. Antony, Ahmed Patel, Janardhan Dwivedi along with Rahul as its members. This was Rahul's moment to take charge. Instead, the committee did not meet even once. (See chapter 3.)

On 16 August, when negotiations on the Lok Pal failed to achieve a breakthrough, the government went ahead and arrested Anna Hazare as he was on his way to the fast site in the national capital. Rahul was informed